lutes in it will hardly be different in essence from the world of either inorganic matter or organic life.

THE LAW OF KARMA

This introduces us to the next Hindu belief, the Law of Karma, or action, which is one of the most well known but least understood by Westerners. The Law of Karma is the renaming of the universally accepted law of causation as applied in the rational and the ethical realms of a man's life. It says that it is a law of the universe that a good action must bear a good result and that a bad action must end in a bad result. It does not only say that it should be so but also that the universe is so constituted that is is so. We cannot pass from an "ought" to a necessary "is." In fact, we pass from an "is" to an "ought," that is, from reality to ideality, and not from our ideality to reality.* Without a firm belief in the Law of Karma, in the sense of being morally responsible for our actions, there is no reason why a sinful man should be different from a sage. This Law of Karma has nothing to do with any doctrine of predestination of a man's actions, or with anything which will make a man a fatalist, or an escapist. Inasmuch as a man is determined by what he has already done in the past and is free to determine what he would like to do in the future, he is both determined and free. In either case he must reap the moral fruits of his deeds. The Law of Karma is just a prerequisite and a presupposition of any moral theory of human conduct. In modern Western ideas also, individuals are supposed to be personally responsible for what they do. Hinduism takes this responsibility to be more real than based only on the force of human society or government or one's own moral conscience. The Hindus have made their ethical laws and values so real that they would obtain in the world even without any human beings in it, if such were the case. The Hindus do not understand how any ethical theory can justify morality or ethics without the existence of an inexorable moral law like other laws of nature in the universe, so that no human being can escape the fruits of his good or bad deeds, even though there be no human agency in the world to dispense the moral rewards and punishments. We

* Suppose we say that we should not kill another living man or that we should love all living beings. It does not mean that our ideal of non-killing or loving is real in the sense that it actually operates in the universe, but rather, that we would like it to operate and to come into being. The Law of Karma goes much beyond this. It says that, though we do not perceive it, all our moral values we believe in are actually and really existent in the universe as its ethical Law of Dharma which the Law of Karma must follow.